

Cognitive Behavioral Practice in Social Work



Cognitive Behavioral Practice



- **Cognitive Behavioral Practice (CBP)** in social work refers to the application of **Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)** principles and techniques within the social work context.
- CBT is an *evidence-based therapeutic* approach that focuses on the connection between *thoughts, emotions, and behaviors*.
- It aims to help individuals understand how their thoughts affect their feelings and actions, and how changing maladaptive thoughts and behaviors can improve their emotional and psychological well-being.



- In social work, **CBP** is used to treat a wide range of issues, including mental health disorders (e.g., anxiety, depression, PTSD), behavioral problems, addiction, and social difficulties.
- Social workers use CBT techniques to help clients develop healthier coping strategies, modify negative thought patterns, and solve problems more effectively.



- **Cognitive Restructuring**
- **Behavioral Activation**
- **Problem-Solving Skills**
- **Graded Exposure**
- **Mood chart**
- **Homework Assignments**
- **Relaxation Techniques**

Cognitive Restructuring



This technique involves helping clients identify *negative, irrational, or distorted thoughts and replace them with more balanced, realistic ones*. It's useful for clients who struggle with self-criticism, anxiety, or distorted thinking.

- **Identify the Negative Thought:** Help the client recognize the automatic negative thought (e.g., "I'm a failure").
- **Challenge the Thought:** Encourage the client to ask questions like: "Is this thought true?", "What evidence do I have for or against this thought?", or "What would I say to a friend in this situation?"
- **Reframe the Thought:** Guide the client to come up with a more realistic, balanced thought (e.g., "I have faced challenges before, and I can learn from this experience").

Behavioral Activation



Behavioral activation focuses on encouraging clients to engage in positive activities that can improve mood and reduce avoidance behaviors, which are often linked to depression or anxiety.

- Including basic tasks like brushing your teeth and doing laundry
- Including social activities that allow you to interact with other people
- BA helps people understand how their behaviors influence their emotions.

Problem-Solving



- **Identify the Problem:** Work with the client to clearly define the problem they are facing.
- **Generate Solutions:** Brainstorm possible solutions with the client, encouraging creativity and openness to different ideas.
- **Evaluate Solutions:** Discuss the pros and cons of each solution, and help the client select the one that seems most feasible.
- **Create an Action Plan:** Develop a step-by-step plan for implementing the chosen solution and set a timeline for follow-up.

Graded Exposure



Graded exposure is used to help clients gradually face situations or thoughts that trigger anxiety, phobias, or avoidance behaviors.

- **Identify Fears or Avoidance Behaviors:** Help the client identify situations or objects they are avoiding due to fear (e.g., social situations, specific locations).
- **Create an Exposure Hierarchy:** Develop a list of these situations, ranked from least to most anxiety-provoking.
- **Gradual Exposure:** Start with the least anxiety-provoking situation and encourage the client to gradually expose themselves to it. Over time, as the client becomes more comfortable, they can work up to more difficult situations.

Mood Chart



The purpose of a mood chart is to help people understand their emotions and mental health by recording their mood over time



SECTION B.

Daily Mood Chart Worksheet

1. How are you feeling today?

	Happy	Sad	Mad	Tired	Excited	Anxious	Other	Daily Notes
6 AM - 8 AM								
8 AM - 10 AM								
10 AM - 12 PM								
12 PM - 2 PM								
2 PM - 4 PM								
4 PM - 6 PM								
6 PM - 8 PM								
8 PM - 10 PM								
10 PM - 12 AM								

2. Rate your general mood today from the highest to the lowest



Place a dot in the box that best describes your mood

	3	2	1	Normal	1	2	3	Daily Notes
SUNDAY								
MONDAY								



Date	Mood Rating (1-10)	Mood Description	Trigger/Context	Automatic Thoughts	Physical Sensations	Behaviors	Coping Strategies	Mood after Coping (1-10)
12/01	4	Anxious	Job interview coming up	"I'm going to mess up."	Tight chest, shallow breathing	Avoiding preparation	Deep breathing, positive self-talk	6
12/02	7	Happy	Spending time with friends	"This is a great day."	Relaxed, smiling	Engaged in conversation	Laughed, stayed present	8
12/03	3	Sad	Arguments with a family member	"I'm always the problem."	Tired, slumped posture	Isolated myself	Took a walk, journaled	5



- **Journaling**, or *keeping a diary*, is an important technique in CBT because it allows clients to see a pattern in their negative thinking patterns and behavior.
- This technique can help us to identify our thought patterns and emotional tendencies, describe them, and change, adapt, or cope with them.



Situation	Emotion (Rate intensity 0–100%)	Thought (Rate belief 0–100% where * = most upsetting thought)
Working late and struggling with a report due for next week. Boss came by to see how I am doing.	Anxious – 90 % Stressed – 100%	1. I'm way behind on this work. – 100% 2. I'll never get this finished on time. – 90% 3. My boss thinks I can't handle this. – 100% 4. *My boss will have me fired. – 100%

Homework



- Often a core part of CBT, homework assignments encourage clients to practice new skills and techniques outside of therapy sessions.
- Example: A client may be asked to keep a journal of their thoughts and feelings related to a specific problem to help identify patterns and triggers.

Coping Skills List

DISTRACTIONS

- ☐ Clean or organize your environment
- ☐ Dance
- ☐ Doodle on a paper
- ☐ Draw
- ☐ Garden
- ☐ Go for a drive
- ☐ Go for a walk
- ☐ Go shopping
- ☐ Hug a stuffed animal
- ☐ Listen to music
- ☐ Paint
- ☐ Photography
- ☐ Play a game
- ☐ Play an instrument
- ☐ Put a puzzle together
- ☐ Read
- ☐ Sing
- ☐ Take a break
- ☐ Take a shower or a bath
- ☐ Watch pets videos on Youtube
- ☐ Watch a movie
- ☐ Write

COGNITIVE COPING

- ☐ Act opposite of negative feelings
- ☐ Brainstorm solutions
- ☐ Make a gratitude list
- ☐ Read an inspirational quote
- ☐ Reward yourself when successful
- ☐ Slowly count to ten
- ☐ Take a class
- ☐ Think about someone you love
- ☐ Think of something funny
- ☐ Use positive self-talk
- ☐ Visualize your favorite place
- ☐ Write a list of goals
- ☐ Write a list of pros and cons for decisions
- ☐ Write a list of strengths
- ☐ Write a positive note

TENSION RELEASERS

- ☐ Chew gum
- ☐ Cry
- ☐ Exercise or play sports
- ☐ Laugh
- ☐ stretch
- ☐ Use a stress ball





Deep Breathing



Progressive muscle relaxation



A relaxation technique that involves tensing and relaxing specific muscle groups to reduce stress.

Grounded Technique



5: Acknowledge FIVE things you see around you. ...

4: Acknowledge FOUR things you can touch around you. ...

3: Acknowledge THREE things you hear. ...

2: Acknowledge TWO things you can smell. ...

1: Acknowledge ONE thing you can taste.

By doing so, it helps shift your focus from anxiety-provoking thoughts to the present moment.

Thankyou